



WINNING THAT GOVERNMENT CONTRACTING AWARD · SESSION 3 OF 4

How to Read a Federal RFP

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Friday, October 2, 2026



Scan now: your worksheet

BEFORE WE START

Scan your worksheet

- 1** **Point your phone camera at the code.** Or click the link in the Zoom chat.
- 2** **Fill in page 1 now.** Name, email, business, where you are today.
- 3** **Open today's practice solicitation too.** Its link is in the chat.

Link is in the Zoom chat

Don't hit Submit until the last slide. When you do, the slides, the compliance matrix template and every link land in your inbox.



TODAY

What we're covering

01 The anatomy of an RFP: Sections A through M

03 The five sections that drive your proposal

05 Building the compliance matrix

02 The reading order that actually works

04 Sections that still need a response

06 Traps that catch small businesses

We read a real one today

TODAY'S PRACTICE SOLICITATION

Janitorial and Carpet Cleaning Services

- **Solicitation:** W912DR26QA051
- **Buyer:** U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, Baltimore District
- **Where:** 125 recruiting offices, 29 in Maryland
- **Set-aside:** Total Small Business Set-Aside
- **Due:** July 13, 2026 (awarded Sept.)

**Real, and
awarded.**

**Link is in the Zoom chat
(DoD's PIEE site, no login).
We read it together all
class.**

Sections A through M

	Sections	What you do with them
Drive your proposal	A · B · C · L · M	Cover page, pricing, the work, instructions, evaluation
Need a response	H · J · K	Special requirements, attachments, reps & certs
Read, then sign	D · E · F · G · I	Packaging, inspection, delivery, admin, FAR clauses

13 sections. About 5 drive what you write.

Our RFQ, mapped to A through M

A → Solicitation memo	number, dates, contact, set-aside
B → Price Schedule.xlsx	priced by region, every site in the region
C → Performance Work Statement	20 pages, 125 addresses
L → Instructions to Offerors	three volumes, how to submit
M → Evaluation Criteria	how they pick the winner

**Different
labels.**

**Same five questions. Ours
arrives as separate
attachments.**

PART 2

The reading order that actually works

PART 2 · READING ORDER



1

A · Cover page

Two minutes: number, due date, who to ask

2

L · Instructions

The recipe: volumes, page limits, format

3

M · Evaluation

How they score you: where to put your effort

4

C · The work

Every "shall" is a requirement

5

B · Pricing

How they want the money presented

6

Then everything else

D through K, before you sign

Stop. Don't read A through M.

SECTION A

The cover page

Two minutes, five facts

- **Solicitation number:** goes on every question and every page you submit
- **Type:** sealed bid (IFB), RFP, or RFQ
- **Issue date and due date:** your clock starts
- **Contracting officer:** the one person you ask questions
- **Issuing office:** who is buying
- **Page count:** how big a lift this is

**Check the
type box.**

**Sealed bid = price decides.
RFP = they score your
approach too.**

SECTION L

Your instruction manual

The recipe

- How many volumes: technical, price, past performance
- What goes in each, and in what order
- Page limits per volume
- Format: font, size, margins
- How and where to submit, and by when
- What *not* to send

If L says it, you do it.

No exceptions. 51 pages on a 50-page limit can be thrown out.

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION A

Read the cover page and the instructions

Open the practice solicitation. In Section A of the worksheet: the due date and time, how to submit, and one instruction you could get wrong.

Link is in the Zoom chat



Lost the tab? Scan again.

SECTION M

How they'll score you

Two ways to win

BEST VALUE TRADE-OFF

Quality can beat price

A stronger proposal at a higher price can win

OR

LPTA

Pass, then cheapest

Meet the technical bar; lowest price wins

- The factors, their weights, and the sub-factors in order

Ours: LPTA. Technical, past performance, price.

SECTION C

The work

Find every "shall"

From our PWS, para. 1

"The Contractor shall establish a complete Quality Control Program ... no later than 30 calendar days after contract award."

From our PWS, para. 3

"Once a month ... the Contractor shall post in each building ... an inspection form."

A SOW tells you how; a PWS tells you the result. Either way, every shall gets an answer.

- Every **"the contractor shall"** is a requirement
- Performance standards and how they're inspected
- Where, when, and how often
- Period of performance: base + option years
- Required staff, clearances, certifications

SECTION B

The pricing structure

How they want the money

What you price	
MD / Northern Virginia	Every site in the region, every line
Eastern PA / DE	Every site in the region, every line
Western PA · Central PA · WV	Bid only the regions you can serve
■ Contract type: ours is firm fixed price ■ Labor rates by category × hours, at or above the wage determination ■ Leave a line blank and you're incomplete	

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION B

Find the scoring and the "shalls"

Section B of the worksheet: how this one is evaluated, two "the contractor shall" statements from the PWS, and one question you'd ask the contracting officer.

Link is in the Zoom chat



Lost the tab? Scan again.

DON'T SKIP THESE

Sections that still need a response

Don't skip these

H · Special requirements

Key personnel, security, local-office rules. Can change your staffing plan.

J · Attachments

Forms to fill and return: past performance questionnaires, pricing sheets, the wage determination.

K · Reps & certs

Your size and status. Mostly in SAM.gov, but some come with the proposal.

D–G, I · Read, then sign

Inspection, delivery, invoicing, FAR clauses. These become your contract terms.

Check every attachment for an action item.

PART 5

Building the compliance matrix

Every requirement, one row

	Requirement	Instruction (L)	Scored under (M)	Proposal section	Status
PWS 1	Quality Control Program in 30 days	Vol I: staffing & mgmt plan	Technical	1.2 QC program	Draft
PWS 1.2	Keep inspection records	Vol I: technical approach	Technical	1.3 QA/QC	Outline
PWS 10	Provide all equipment & supplies	Vol I: equipment list	Technical	1.4 Equipment	Not started
Wage det.	Pay SCA rates	Vol III: price	Price	Price schedule	In review

If only one tool leaves with you, make it this one.

Six steps to build it

1 Read L List every instruction: volumes, limits, format	2 Read M List every factor and sub-factor	3 Read C One row per "shall"
4 Map Each row to its L location and M factor	5 Outline Your proposal outline falls out of the matrix	6 Track Writing status and review, row by row

Build the matrix before you write a single word.

Spot the conflict

- Evaluation Criteria: **3** similar projects in the past **5** years
- Past performance questionnaire: **2** references in the past **3** years
- The questionnaire calls relevant work "crane support and inspection"

**Ask. In
writing.**

**That's what the question
deadline is for.**

HOW IT ENDED

Who won

	Based in	BPA value on the award notice
Crystal Cleanz LLC	Germantown, MD	\$4,956,097
Greenfield International Corp.	Woodbridge, VA	\$4,979,445
Integrity Core Alliance LLC	Austell, GA	\$2,853,298

Three small businesses. One is from Germantown.

Traps that catch small businesses

CAN SINK YOU

- Breaking a format or page-limit rule
- Missing a "shall"
- Treating the attachments as FYI
- Missing the due time or time zone

COSTS YOU POINTS

- Reading it once instead of three times
- Writing to what you do, not to Section M
- Skipping the Q&A window
- Writing before building the matrix

TODAY

What to remember

1

A → L → M → C → B

Not front to back

2

L is the recipe

Follow it exactly

3

M is how you win

One win theme per factor

4

Every "shall" counts

Each one gets a row

5

Matrix first

Then outline, then write

6

Ask during Q&A

Guessing wrong is on you

Submit your worksheet

MONDAY, OCT 5 · 10:00 A.M. · SESSION 4

Basics of proposal writing

- Writing to the evaluation criteria
- Structuring each section
- Standing out in a stack of 20
- Bring your compliance matrix

WORKSHEET · SECTION C

Write your one step, then submit.

Your inbox gets: this deck with notes, the compliance matrix template, the practice solicitation link, and [acquisition.gov](https://www.acquisition.gov).





Questions?

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